

THE IDEALIZED SELF-IMAGE

Greetings, God bless all of you, my dearest friends. Welcome are all my old and new friends gathered here.

Let us continue with the series of lectures so as to help you gain further insight into yourselves and therefore into life. The two preceding lectures dealt with the great duality, the struggle between life and death, the illusion that it is a question of either/or. The more one is involved in a duality, the more one sees life in terms of extremes. So also is the question of happiness versus unhappiness felt in two extremes, in terms of either/or, with happiness standing for life, and unhappiness for death.

While still struggling in this duality, it is impossible to experience and accept the realization that life brings both. It is often accepted and believed in the intellect, but emotionally it is felt, "If I am unhappy now, I must always be unhappy." And then the tragically unnecessary and destructive struggle against death or unhappiness begins.

The very event of birth is a painful experience for the infant. Other painful experiences are bound to follow. On the other hand, pleasurable experiences exist as well. Since the knowledge of the unpleasurable experiences, or their possibility, is always present, the fear of them creates a basic problem in man. It is the problem we have discussed in the last two lectures.

Now I would like to discuss the most important countermeasure man resorts to in the false belief that it will circumvent unhappiness, unpleasure, death, never realizing that this very countermeasure not only does not avoid, but brings on the very thing that is most dreaded and fought against. This common, universal pseudoprotection is the creation of the idealized self-image. I have discussed this topic quite frequently with friends in their private work, but could do so only to a limited extent. The reason I could not go into more detail or discuss it in the public lectures so far is obvious, my friends. It had to follow suit to the last two lectures. If you do not fully understand your struggle between duality, you cannot fully understand the creation and the function of the idealized self-image.

It is supposed to be a means of avoiding unhappiness. Since unhappiness automatically robs the child of security, self-confidence is diminished according to the unhappiness and ensuing lack of security. This unhappiness cannot be measured objectively. What one personality may be able to cope with quite well and does not experience as drastic unhappiness, another temperament and character feels as dismal woe. At any rate, unhappiness and lack of belief in oneself are interconnected. Hence, the creation of the idealized self-image serves the purpose of obtaining the missing self-confidence. Thereby pleasure supreme can be gained. This is the unconscious reasoning process. It is not altogether different from the truth. In truth and reality, healthy and

genuine self-confidence is peace of mind. It is security and healthy independence. It also achieves a maximum of happiness through developing one's inherent talents, leading a constructive life, and having fruitful human relationships in healthy interdependence. But since the self-confidence established through the idealized self is artificial and not genuine, the result cannot possibly be what was expected. Actually the consequence is quite the contrary and frustrating only because cause and effect are not obvious to the person. It may take him a great deal of life experience and inner will to find the truth about himself. Then and then only will he slowly discover the links between the unhappiness and his idealized self-image. This is the work to be done by those who follow this path, and some of my friends have already made some preliminary discoveries in this direction, but there is much more to it. Even you who have gained some insight in this respect have barely scratched the surface. None of you has grasped the significance, the effects, the damages that follow in the wake of it. You have not even fully recognized its existence, in what particular way it manifests in your individual case. This requires a great deal of work for which all the preceding work was necessary. But the dissolution of the idealized self is the only possible way to find your true self, to find serenity and self-respect, and to live your life fully.

There is much to be said about this topic, but tonight I can only go into the barest fundamentals. As time goes on, I shall be more specific and go into further details. But more important are the results and findings of your personal work in this respect.

I have occasionally used the term mask self in the past. The mask self and the idealized self-image are really one and the same. The idealized self masks the real self. It pretends to be something you are not. As a child, regardless of what your particular circumstances were, you were indoctrinated with admonitions on the importance of being good, holy, perfect. When you were not so, you were often punished in one way or another. Perhaps the worst punishment was that your parents withdrew their affection from you, they were angry, and you had the impression you were no longer loved. No wonder that "badness" associated itself with punishment and unhappiness; "goodness" with reward and happiness. Hence, the need to be "good" and "perfect" became an absolute must; it became literally a question of life or death for you. On the other hand, you knew perfectly well that you were not as good and as perfect as the world seemed to expect you to be. This truth had to be hidden as a guilty secret, and you started to build up a false self. This, you thought, was your protection and your means of attaining what you desperately want -- life, happiness, security, self-confidence. Slowly the awareness of this false front began to vanish, but you were and are permanently permeated with the guilt of pretending to be something you are not. You strain harder and harder to become this false self, this idealized self. You were, and unconsciously still are, convinced that if you strain hard enough, one day you will be it. But this artificial squeezing-into-something-you-are-not process can never attain genuine self-improvement, self-purification, and growth because you start building on an unreal self and leave your real self out of commission. In fact, you are desperately hiding it.

The idealized self-image may have many forms and facets. It does not always dictate standards of recognized perfection. Oh yes, much of the idealized self-image dictates highly moral standards, making it all the more difficult to question its validity. "But isn't it right to want to be always decent, loving, understanding; never to be angry; not wanting to have any faults; trying to attain perfection? Isn't this what we are supposed to do?" Such considerations will make it difficult for you to discover the compulsive attitude that excludes the present imperfection, the pride and lack of humility in which you cannot accept yourself as you are now, and, above all, the pretense

with its resulting shame, fear of exposure, secretiveness, tension, strain, guilt, anxiety. It will take some progress in this work before you begin to experience the difference in feeling between the genuine desire for gradually working towards growth, and the ungentle pretense imposed upon you by the dictates of your idealized self. You will discover the deeply hidden fear in which you believe your world has come to an end if you do not live up to any of these standards. You will sense and know many other aspects and differences of the genuine and the ungentle self. And you will also discover what your particular idealized self demands.

But there are also facets of the idealized self -- according to personality, life conditions, and early influences -- which are not and cannot be considered good, ethical, or moral. Aggressive, hostile, proud, overambitious trends are glorified or idealized. It is true that behind all idealized self-images these negative tendencies exist. But they are hidden, and since they crassly contradict the morally high standards of the particular idealized self, they cause additional anxiety in that the idealized self will be exposed as the fraud that it is. But the person who glorifies such negative tendencies, believing them to prove his strength and independence, his superiority and aloofness, will be deeply ashamed of the "goodness" another person's idealized self proclaims as a must, considering it as weakness, vulnerability, and dependency in an unhealthy sense. It is entirely overlooked that nothing makes a person as vulnerable as pride. Nothing causes so much fear.

In most cases, a combination of these two tendencies exist: on the one hand, overexacting moral standards impossible to live up to, and on the other, a pride in being invulnerable, aloof, and superior. The existence of these mutually exclusive ways presents a particular hardship for the psyche. Needless to say, the conscious awareness of this contradiction is missing until this particular work is well in progress.

There are many more facets, possibilities, individual pseudosolutions combining all sorts of mutually exclusive trends. But all this has to be found individually. Let us now consider some of the general effects of the existence of the idealized self and some of the implications.

Since the standards and dictates of the idealized self are impossible to realize, yet never giving up the attempt, you keep and cultivate within yourself an inner tyranny of the worst order. But since you do not realize the impossibility of being as perfect as your idealized self demands, you never give up whipping yourself, castigating yourself, and feeling yourself a complete failure whenever it is proven that you cannot do so. The sense of abject worthlessness comes over you whenever you fall short of these fantastic demands, and engulfs you in misery. This misery may at times be conscious, but most of the time it is not. Even if it is, you do not realize the entire significance, the impossibility of your demands. And when you try to hide your reactions to your own "failure," you take to special means in order not to become aware of your "failure." One of the most common devices is projection into the outer world, onto others, onto life. This we have discussed at length in the past, but you will now understand the deepest reason of such projections.

The more you try to identify with your idealized self-image, the harder is the disillusionment whenever life brings you into a position when this masquerade can no longer be maintained. Many a personal crisis is based on this factor, and much less on the outer difficulties. But these difficulties then become an added menace, beyond their objective hardship. The existence of the difficulties is a proof to you that you are not your idealized self, and that robs you of the false self-confidence you tried to establish with the idealized self.

There are other types of personality who know perfectly well that they cannot identify with their idealized self. But they do not know this in a healthy way. They despair. They believe they ought to be able to live up to it. Their whole life is permeated with a sense of failure, while the former type only experiences it on more conscious levels when outer and inner conditions culminate in showing up the phantom of the idealized self for what it really is -- an illusion, a pretense, a dishonesty. It amounts to saying: "I know I am imperfect, but I make believe I am not." To recognize this dishonesty is comparatively easy. It is rationalized by the claim of conscientiousness, honorable standards and goals, a desire to be good.

The genuine desire to better oneself accepts the personality as it now is as the basic premise. If this is the main governing force of your motivation for perfection, any discovery where you fall short of your ideals will not throw you into depression, anxiety, and guilt. It will rather strengthen you. You will not need to exaggerate the "badness" of the trend in question; nor will you defend yourself against it with the excuse it is the fault of others, of life, of fate. You will gain an objective view of yourself in this respect, and this view will liberate you. You will fully assume responsibility for the faulty attitude, being willing to take the consequences upon yourself. When you act out of your idealized self, you dread nothing more than that. For, taking the responsibility for your shortcomings upon yourself is tantamount to saying, "I am not my idealized self."

Sense of failure, frustration, and compulsion, as well as guilt and shame, are the most outstanding indications of your idealized self being at work. These are the consciously felt emotions of all that lies hidden underneath.

The idealized self has been called into existence in order to attain self-confidence and therefore, finally, happiness, pleasure supreme. The stronger its existence or presence, the more genuine self-confidence or remnants of it fade away. Since you cannot live up to these standards, you think even less of yourself than you originally did. It is therefore obvious that genuine self-confidence can only be established when you remove the superstructure of this merciless tyrant of your idealized self.

Yes, you could have self-confidence if, on the one hand, the idealized self were really you and if, on the other, you could live up to these standards. But since this is impossible and since deep down you know perfectly well you are not anything like what you think you are supposed to be with this "super self," you build up an additional insecurity. Thereby, further vicious circles come into existence. For instance, the original insecurity, supposed to be whisked away by the establishment of the idealized self, steadily increases. It snowballs, and becomes worse and worse. The more insecure you feel, the more stringent the demands of the superstructure, the idealized self, the less are you able to live up to it, and the more insecure do you feel. It is very important to realize this vicious circle. But this cannot be done until and unless you become fully aware of the devious, subtle, unconscious ways that this idealized self-image exists in your particular case. In what particular areas does it manifest mostly? What are cause and effect connected with it?

A further and most drastic result of this problem is the constantly increasing estrangement from the real self. The idealized self, as I said, is a falsity. It is a rigidly, artificially constructed imitation of a live human being. You may invest many aspects of your real being into it. Nevertheless, it still remains an artificial construction. The more you invest into it of your energies,

of your personality, of your thought processes, concepts, ideas, and ideals, the more strength you take from that center of your being which alone is amenable to growth. This center of your being is the only part of you, the real you, that can live, grow, and be. It is the only thing that can properly guide you. It alone functions with all your capacities. It is flexible and intuitive. Its feelings alone are true and valid even if, for the moment, they are not yet fully in truth and reality, in perfection and purity. But the feelings of the real self function in perfection relative to what you are now, not being able to be more as applied to any given situation of your life. But the more you take out of that live-center in order to invest into the robot you have created, the more estranged you become from the real self, and the more you weaken and impoverish it.

In the course of this work, you have sometimes come upon the puzzling and often frightening question: "Who am I really?" This is the result of the discrepancy and struggle between the real and the false self.

Only upon solving this most vital and profound question will the live-center of you respond and function to its full capacity; will your intuition begin to function to its full capacity; will you become spontaneous, free of all compulsions; will you trust in your feelings because they will have an opportunity to mature and grow. Feelings will become every bit as reliable to you as your reasoning power and your intellect. All this is the final finding of self. But before this can be done, a great many hurdles have to be overcome. It seems to you as a struggle for life or death. You still believe you need the idealized self in order to live and be happy. Once you understand that this is not so, you will be able to give up the pseudodefense that makes it seem necessary to maintain and cultivate the idealized self. Once you understand that the idealized self was supposed to solve your problems, the particular problems in your life, above and beyond the generality of happiness, pleasure, and security, you will come to see the wrong conclusion of this theory. Once you go a step still further and recognize the damage it has brought into your life, you will shed it as the burden it is. No conviction, theory, or words you hear will make you give it up. But the recognition of what particularly it was supposed to solve and what damage it has done and is continuing to do will enable you to dissolve this basic image of all images. Needless to say, you also have to recognize most particularly and in detail what your specific demands and standards are; and further, you have to see their unreasonableness, their impossibility. When you have a feeling of acute anxiety and depression, consider the fact that your idealized self may be questioned and threatened, either by your own limitation, by others, or by life. Recognize the self-contempt that underlies the anxiety or depression. Or when you are compulsively angry with others, consider the possibility that this is but an externalization of your anger with yourself for not living up to your false self. Do not let it get away with the excuse of existent outer problems to account for the acute depression or fear. Look into this question from this new angle. Your private and personal work will help you in this direction. It is almost impossible to do it alone. Only after you have made some substantial progress in this direction will you recognize that so many of these outer problems are directly or indirectly the result of the conflict between your capacities and the standards of your idealized self and how you deal with this conflict.

So, as you proceed in this particular phase of the work, you will come to understand the exact nature of your idealized self, your demands, your requirements of self and others in order to maintain the illusion. Once you fully see that that which you regarded as commendable is really pride and pretense, you will have gained a most substantial insight that enables you to weaken the impact of the idealized self. Then and then only will you realize the tremendous self-punishment

you inflict upon yourself. For, whenever you fall short, as you are bound to, you feel so impatient, so irritated that such impatience and irritation can snowball into fury and wrath at yourself. Oh, this fury and wrath is often projected onto others because it is too unbearable to be aware of self-hate unless one unrolls this whole process and sees it in the entire light. Nevertheless, even if this hate is unloaded upon others, the effect on the self is still there. It can cause disease, accident, loss, and outer failure in many ways.

When you make the very first steps toward giving up the idealized self, you will feel a sense of liberation as never before. Then will you truly be born again. That is, your real self will emerge. Then you will rest within your real self, being centered within. Then and then only will you truly succeed in making yourself grow -- not only on the outer fringes that may have been free of the idealized self dictatorship, but wholly and fully free, taking in every part of your being. This will change many things. First will come changes in your reactions to life, to incidents, to yourself and others. This changed reaction will be quite astounding enough. But little by little, outer things are also bound to change. Your different attitude will cause new effects. The overcoming of your idealized self means overcoming an important facet of the duality between life and death.

At present you are not even aware of the pressure of your idealized self, of the shame, humiliation, exposure you fear and sometimes feel, of the tension, strain, and compulsion. If you have an occasional glimpse of such emotions, you do not as yet connect them with the fantastic demands of your idealized self. Only after fully seeing these fantastic expectations and their often contradictory trends, will you relinquish them. The initial inner freedom gained in this way will allow you to deal with life and to stand in life. You will no longer have to hold on frantically to this idealized self. The mere inner activity of holding on frantically, generates a pervasive climate of holding on in general. This is sometimes lived out in external attitudes, but most often it is an inner quality or attitude. As you proceed in this new phase of your work, you will sense and feel this inner tightness, and gradually you will recognize the basic damage of it. It makes impossible the letting go of many an attitude. It makes unduly difficult going through any change that would allow life to bring forth joy and a spirit of vigor. You keep yourself contained within yourself, and thereby you go against life in one of its most fundamental aspects.

The words are very insufficient. You have rather to sense what I mean. But you will know exactly what I mean when you have arrived at weakening your idealized self considerably by the mere process of fully understanding its function, its causes and effects. Then you will gain the great freedom of giving yourself to life because you no longer have to hide something from yourself and others. You will be able to squander yourself into life, not in an unhealthy, unreasonable way, but healthily as nature squanders herself. Then and then only will you know the beauty of living.

You cannot approach this most important part of your inner work by a general concept. As usual, your most insignificant daily reactions, considered from this viewpoint, will yield the necessary result. So continue your self-search out of these new considerations, and do not be impatient if it takes time and relaxed effort.

I have one more word. The difference between the real and the idealized self is often not a question of quantity (as regards the goodness or badness of a trend) but rather one of quality. That is, the original motivation is different between these two selves. This will not be easy to see, but as you recognize the demands, the contradictions, and cause and effects sequence, the difference in

motivation will gradually become clear to you. Another important consideration is the time element between these two selves. The idealized self wants to be perfect (according to its specific demands) right now. The real self knows this cannot be and does not suffer from this fact. Of course, you are not perfect in your real self. It is a complex of everything you are at the moment. Of course, you have your basic egocentricity. But since you own up to it, you can cope with it. You can learn to understand it and therefore diminish it with each new insight in this respect.

Then you will truly experience the following words. The more egocentric you are, the less can you have of self-confidence. The idealized self believes just the opposite. Its claims for perfection are motivated by sheerly egocentric reasons. And this very egocentricity makes self-confidence impossible.

So this great freedom of coming home, my friends, is finding your way back to the real you. The expression "coming home" has often been used in spiritual literature and teachings. But it has been much misunderstood. It is often interpreted to mean the return into the spirit world after physical death. Much more is meant by coming home. You may die many deaths, one earth life after another, but if you have not found your real self, you cannot come home. You must be lost and remain lost until you do find the way into the center of your being. On the other hand, you can find your way home right here and right now while you are still in the body. When you muster the courage of becoming your real self, even though it would seem to be much less than the idealized self, you will find out that it is much more. And then you will have the peace of being at home within yourself. Then will you find security. Then will you function as a whole human being. Then will you have eliminated the iron whip of a task master whom it is impossible to obey. Then will you know what peace and security really means. You will cease, once and for all, to seek it by false means.

And now, my dear ones, I am ready for your questions.

QUESTION: So the real self does not have two souls, no duality?

ANSWER: Of course not. The duality ceases to exist once you accept yourself as part good and part bad as consisting partly of the higher and partly of the lower self. These two sides will be integrated and live in peace with one another once you accept yourself with both. And only then can the lower side gradually develop and grow out of its blindness. But as long as you do not reconcile yourself that you are both good and bad, as long as you battle against this "badness" and believe you must not have it now, duality will exist. By accepting your lower self, you can gradually overcome it and, as well, the duality between the higher and the lower self. By nonacceptance, you increase the duality. It is the same question I discussed regarding life and death. By accepting death, the duality between life and death is gradually decreased until it disappears altogether. By struggling against death as you struggle against your lower self, the duality increases.

QUESTION: Could you tell us what Goethe meant with the saying "Two souls dwell in my breast"?

ANSWER: It can be interpreted to mean the higher and the lower self. And it can also be interpreted to mean the duality between the idealized and the real self. The lack of peace between

the higher and the lower self brings the idealized self into existence. These two dualities are interdependent.

You see, the more the idealized self is put between the real self and life, the less can life grow; and the more does it shrink and become prohibited from functioning.

QUESTION: In modern psychology we hear frequently the word "schizophrenia," and it is applied to those who are psychotic. According to your talk this evening and previously, we are all disintegrated and split. Is this duality only a matter of degree?

ANSWER: Yes, it is a matter of degree, of intensity, and of how many areas of the personality this includes. With the clinical psychotic, the areas of nonacceptance of self are overwhelming. With more normal persons functioning in life, the idealized self may pervade the whole personality, but there may still be a certain sense of the reality.

QUESTION: In the last lecture, we learned that it is important for us to face death in order to live fully. There is, at present, great publicity given to the trial of Adolf Eichmann. I have three questions. Can we and should we try to face the death of these millions of unfortunates in order to learn something for ourselves individually? Is it healthy to revive an era of death and destruction? Can any positive lesson be learned by mankind through reviving this?

ANSWER: First I will answer the question: can any lesson be learned as to the subject of life and death, or any other topic, for that matter? That depends entirely on the individual, whether or not he can or wants to learn a lesson. But as to the lesson of death, I venture to say that every individual has to go through that himself, whether it be actual physical death or the many little everyday dyings I discussed recently. I think it would be very dangerous to assume that one person can learn through the tragedy of another in this particular sense. It would be dangerous because it would make for a smugness, possibly even winding up in passive or eventually even into active cruelty. It might condone cruelty in an insidious and subtle way. Certain things one can learn only by going through them oneself. There are other ways by which one could, at least theoretically, learn through other people's experiences if one is open for it. However, experience shows most of the time that most individuals have to learn their own lessons through their own mistakes, not by the mistakes that others make and not by the experiences others have. If in isolated cases this does occur, all the better. But there is no general law that can proclaim one particular happening more conducive to learn from than from others. Theoretically, one could learn from any occurrence in life. Mostly it is easier to learn a lesson from one's own tiny insignificant disappointment than by another person's tragedy.

As to the second question, my dear friends, I cannot answer that with a yes or a no. Again it depends on the individual. A positive lesson could be learned by individuals, as well as by mankind in general, by recalling this era of destruction and cruelty. And a negative lesson could also be learned through it. By the same token, a positive as well as a negative lesson could be learned by not reviving it. There is no yes or no. There is no pat answer to either of these two alternatives.

So long as mankind is governed mostly by vindictiveness, by hatred, and by revenge, and these emotions remain predominant, there will be no lesson. If, on the other hand, the main motivations are truly and genuinely more constructive than destructive (not only proclaimed, but felt), the lesson

will be a positive one. On the other hand, not reviving it could also happen out of negative motives such as cowardice, fear, indifference, opportunism, resignation. This would then be a negative lesson also. Not reviving it could as well come out of a true wisdom that the laws of the divine world take care of everything. But this certainly does not mean that criminals should not pay the consequences. But the approach of taking it upon oneself to punish another human being is a very different one from the approach of making further cruelty impossible while healing the criminal of his disease -- if he is at all willing to accept the necessary help.

QUESTION: To what extent should men take it upon themselves to punish a criminal?

ANSWER: It is not up to man to punish. His course of action should be, and one day will be, to also take upon himself the responsibility that any crime can happen through wrong values, wrong systems, wrong education, wrong attitudes. In that recognition, the weight will be shifted from punishment to healing. But the possibility of perpetrating further crime by such a person should be strictly avoided by curtailing his outer freedom while helping him to gain his inner freedom through treatment. This would feel like punishment anyway for the criminal; for the infringement of his personal freedom, as well as the painful process of healing his soul, may be every bit as difficult as death or life in prison, only it would be much more constructive. All this will come about one day.

May you all find truth and help and further enlightenment through the words I gave you tonight. However, you should understand and expect that a theoretical understanding, especially now, will avail you nothing. As long as these words remain theory, you will not be helped by them. When you begin or continue to work in this direction and allow yourself to feel and observe your emotional reactions as to this subject, then will you make substantial progress in your own liberation and self-finding in the truest sense of the word.

Now my dearest ones, each one of you, receive our love, our strength, and our blessings. Be in peace, be in God!

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